

A FREE DM TABLE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

THE SUN GETS A TURN

A d20 for what the desert does on its own initiative.

d20 + d10 · four bands · one printable card · system-agnostic (SRD 5.1)

A d20 for what the desert does on its own initiative, and a d10 for why today is worse than usual.

Use it: any fight, chase or crossing in dry country. Roll the d10 once when the party sets out. Roll the d20 on initiative count 20, once a round. No stat blocks, nothing to convert, and every row runs on rules your table already knows.



THE PROBLEM

Your players are four days into a hundred miles of dry country and the only thing that has happened to them is a giant scorpion.

That is not a monster problem. The scorpion was fine. The problem is that for four days the most dangerous thing in the scene has been sitting there doing nothing, and the way you have been running it, the desert is a beige room with an encounter table bolted to the wall.

Then the boss fight starts, and it is a beige room with a boss in it.

The fix is not more encounters. You do not need another creature. You need the land to take a turn, the same way anything else in the fight takes a turn, and you need it to cost something other than hit points.

I have been running games for 30+ years and I ran deserts badly for most of them. What changed it was not better description. It was giving the place an initiative count.



THE THREE RULES

1. GIVE IT INITIATIVE 20

The desert acts on initiative count 20, losing ties. That is the slot the rules already hand to a lair, so your table understands it before you explain it. On the desert's turn, roll the d20 below or pick the row you want.

One row a round is right. Two is a set piece, and a set piece should be something you decided on before the session, not something the dice did to you.

Outside combat it is the same idea on a slower clock: roll once per hour of hard travel, or once per leg of the journey if you are covering ground fast.

It hits everybody. The desert does not take sides, and a table notices fast if it only ever lands on the players. There is one exception and it is worth more than a rule: things born out here have already solved the grit and the sun angle, so rows 7 and 15 skip them. Your party squints. The thing they are fighting does not.

2. ALMOST NONE OF IT IS DAMAGE, ON PURPOSE

Read down the table. Two rows deal a point or two. Everything else takes footing, sight, sound, water, or a turn.

A desert that deals 4 damage a round is a bad monster with no stat block, and your players will treat it the way they treat weather in a video game. A desert that has the archer squinting into the sun, the wizard's focus thirty feet downwind, and the only shade on the map sliding away from the wounded is the fight.

3. TELL THEM IT IS COMING

The dust wall is visible for a full minute before it arrives. The shade is obviously going to move, because the sun is obviously moving. Say so.

Announced pressure makes players plan. Unannounced pressure makes them fatalistic, and a fatalistic table stops trying things, which is the exact thing you were trying to fix.



ABOUT THE HEAT CLOCK

Two rows below say the heat “ticks.” Use whatever your table already uses for that.

If you use nothing, use this: mark a box for every hour a character spends in the open with the sun up. On the fourth box, one level of exhaustion. The boxes clear on a long rest taken in shade with water to spare.

The rulebook has its own numbers for thirst and they are stricter than mine. Use those if your table wants the survival game played straight. This version exists so the clock is one line you can hold in your head while you are also running a fight.



THE KEY

Four bands of five. Find the band, read the row.

THE KEY: READ THIS FIRST

ROLL	THE BAND	WHAT IT COVERS
1-5	Underfoot	The ground stops being a floor
6-10	The air	What the wind does, and what it carries off
11-15	Light and heat	The sun as a working part of the fight
16-20	What else is out there	Something has noticed. Or nothing has, which is worse



D20: WHAT THE DESERT DOES ON ITS TURN

UNDERFOOT

D20	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The crust gives. Whoever is standing on the flattest, most confident piece of ground goes shin-deep into brine and grit. They are prone, and standing up costs their whole movement instead of half.
2	The slope runs. The face of the nearest dune slides. Every creature on it travels 10 feet downhill, and whoever was at the back of the climb is now in front.
3	Something surfaces. A wheel. A roof beam. A hand. One creature’s movement uncovers a piece of a buried building. It is half cover for anyone who wants it, and it is the first honest evidence that people used to live out here.
4	The ground bites. Anything lying on it starts to cook. A creature that is prone at the start of its turn takes 2 fire damage when it gets up, and so does anyone who put a bare palm down. Dropped metal is too hot to pick up for a minute.
5	Sand-glass. A sheet of fused glass under a skin of dust, twenty feet across, and nobody can see where it ends. Difficult terrain. A creature that ends its turn on it makes a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or falls prone.

THE AIR

D20 WHAT HAPPENS

- 6 **The wind takes the words.** Until the end of the next round, nobody hears anything past 30 feet. Spoken spell components still work, because those are said to the spell and not to a friend. Shouted orders do not. The plan they made last round is the plan they have.
- 7 **Grit.** Every creature without something across its face has disadvantage on attacks against targets more than 30 feet away, until it spends an action clearing its eyes.
- 8 **A gust takes something light.** A hat. An unrolled map. A torch. A focus somebody set down for one second. Pick the thing that will cost the most to lose and put it 30 feet downwind.
- 9 **The air goes dead still.** This is not relief. Until the end of the next round sound carries perfectly: advantage on Perception checks that rely on hearing, for everyone in the scene, including whatever is out past the light. The heat gets a free tick.
- 10 **The dust arrives.** Everything past 30 feet is heavily obscured until the end of the next round. Then it moves on, and they get to see who used the time.

LIGHT AND HEAT

D20 WHAT HAPPENS

- 11 **The light goes flat.** No shadows anywhere, so nothing has depth and nothing has a distance. Ranged attacks past half their normal range are at disadvantage until a creature spends an action ranging the shot for everyone.
- 12 **Water, out at the edge of it.** It is not water. Any creature that has gone a day without a full skin makes a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw or spends its next movement walking toward it.
- 13 **Metal turns on you.** Anyone in metal armor, or holding an unwrapped metal weapon, has disadvantage on their next Constitution saving throw, and the heat ticks for them and for nobody else.
- 14 **The shade moves.** The one patch of shade in the scene slides 20 feet. Whoever was in it is not now, and getting back into it means crossing open ground while somebody watches them do it.
- 15 **The sun tips over.** The angle drops. Every creature facing into it has disadvantage on ranged attacks until it moves to a different facing. This row costs nothing and almost nobody uses it.

WHAT ELSE IS OUT THERE

D20 WHAT HAPPENS

- 16 **Something starts circling.** High up and patient, in no hurry at all. It is not a threat. It is an announcement, and everything on the horizon can read it.
- 17 **The small things come up.** A 15-foot radius around the loudest creature is difficult terrain until the end of the next round. Anything that ends its turn inside it takes 1 poison damage and spends the next hour finding legs inside its clothing.
- 18 **Something comes to drink.** A creature you have not introduced yet walks past the fight and goes for the party's waterskins, not the party. If they let it drink, it leaves. If they do not, they learn what it is.
- 19 **A fresh track crosses theirs.** Big, deep, and heading the other way at speed. Whatever made it was not hunting. It was leaving.
- 20 **Nothing.** No wind. No sound. Nothing moving anywhere on the horizon. Skip the desert's turn and run the round as normal. After four rounds of the land doing something, one round of it doing nothing is the loudest row on this table.

D10: WHY TODAY IS WORSE THAN USUAL

Roll once, before they set out. It is the frame the whole day sits in, and it is the one thing on this page the players should be able to work out for themselves by noon.

THE DAY'S CONDITION, ROLLED ONCE

D10 WHAT HAPPENS

- 1 **The wind has been up for three days.** Everyone's eyes are raw before anything begins. Sight-based Perception is at disadvantage until they get an hour out of the wind.
- 2 **The water is short.** Somebody sold them four skins and filled three. They will find out at the worst hour of the worst day, which is the only way anybody ever finds this out.
- 3 **It rained a month ago.** There is green in the low ground. Everything alive out here is therefore also in the low ground, and the low ground is the easy walking.
- 4 **It is the hottest week in nine years.** The last three people they passed said so, and none of them stopped to explain.
- 5 **Something died upwind.** Roll on the 16 to 20 band twice as often today.
- 6 **A caravan is half a day ahead.** Its ruts are the only good footing for miles, and following them means arriving after whatever the caravan already woke.
- 7 **The nights are wrong this month.** Cold enough that a watch stood without a fire costs a level of exhaustion, and a fire out here can be seen from a very long way off.
- 8 **The salt is blowing.** Every cut stings, every skin tastes wrong, and anything steel wants oiling tonight or it starts to pit by morning.
- 9 **There is a wind that arrives at the same hour every afternoon,** and the people who live here plan their whole day around being somewhere else when it does. The party has not met anybody who lives here.
- 10 **Nothing is wrong.** Good weather. Full skins. Easy footing. Every local they passed on the road this morning was going the other way.

THE CARD

The whole thing, in the shape you keep open next to you.

The three rules

1. The desert acts on initiative 20, losing ties. One row a round.
2. It takes footing, sight, sound, water or a turn. It almost never takes hit points.
3. Announce it before it lands. Announced pressure makes plans; surprise pressure makes shrugs.

The bands

- **1-5 Underfoot.** The ground stops being a floor.
- **6-10 The air.** What the wind does, and what it carries off.
- **11-15 Light and heat.** The sun as a working part of the fight.
- **16-20 What else is out there.** Something has noticed, or nothing has.

The heat clock, if you do not have one

One box per hour in the open sun. Four boxes, one level of exhaustion. Clears on a long rest in shade with water to spare.

Roll the d10 once, at the start

It is the day, not the round. The party should be able to work out which row you rolled by about noon.



RUNNING THIS SOMEWHERE OTHER THAN FIFTH EDITION

Almost all of it travels, because almost none of it is a number.

Two rows of the d20 name a number, and it is the same number both times: rows 5 and 12 each ask for a DC 10 saving throw. Swap in whatever your system calls a test a competent character passes most of the time. Rows 4 and 17 of the d20 name small damage values, and the smallest meaningful hit in your game will do instead.

The initiative-20 slot is the only structural piece, and it needs a system with an initiative order. In games without one, run the d20 on the same beat you already use for pressure: a clock tick, a failed test, or a scene turn.

The d10 needs nothing at all. It is a fact about the day.



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